# THE SISTER OF SLEEP

*The brief arc of our days,*
*O Sestius,*
*prevents us from launching*
*prolonged hopes. (I, 4)*

In the third part of the great Indian epic the Mahābhārata, a powerful spirit named Yaksa asks the oldest and wisest of the Pandava, Yudhistira, what is the greatest of all mysteries. The answer given resounds across millennia: "Every day countless people die, and yet those who remain live as if they were immortals."[128]

I would not wish to live as if I were immortal. I do not fear death. I fear suffering. And I fear old age, though less so now that I am witnessing the tranquil and pleasant old age of my father. I am afraid of frailty, and of the absence of love. But death does not alarm me. It did not scare me when I was young, and I thought at the time that this was because it was such a remote prospect. But now, at sixty, the fear has yet to arrive. I love life, but life is also struggle, suffering, pain. I think of death as akin to a well-earned rest. The sister of sleep, Bach calls it, in his marvelous cantata BWV 56. A kindly sister, who will come quickly to close my eyes and caress my head.

Job died when he was "full of days." It's a wonderful expression. I, too, would like to arrive at the point of feeling "full of days," and to close with a smile the brief circle that is our life. I can still take pleasure in it, yes; still enjoy the moon reflected on the sea, the kisses of the woman I love, her presence that gives meaning to everything; still savor those Sunday afternoons at home in winter, lying on the sofa filling pages with symbols and formulae, dreaming of capturing another small secret from among the thousands that still surround us. . . . I like to look forward to still tasting from this golden chalice, to life that is teeming, both tender and hostile, clear and inscrutable, unexpected. . . . But I have already drunk deep of the bittersweet contents of this chalice, and if an angel were to come for me right now, saying, "Carlo, it's time," I would not ask to be left even long enough to finish this sentence. I would just smile up at him and follow.